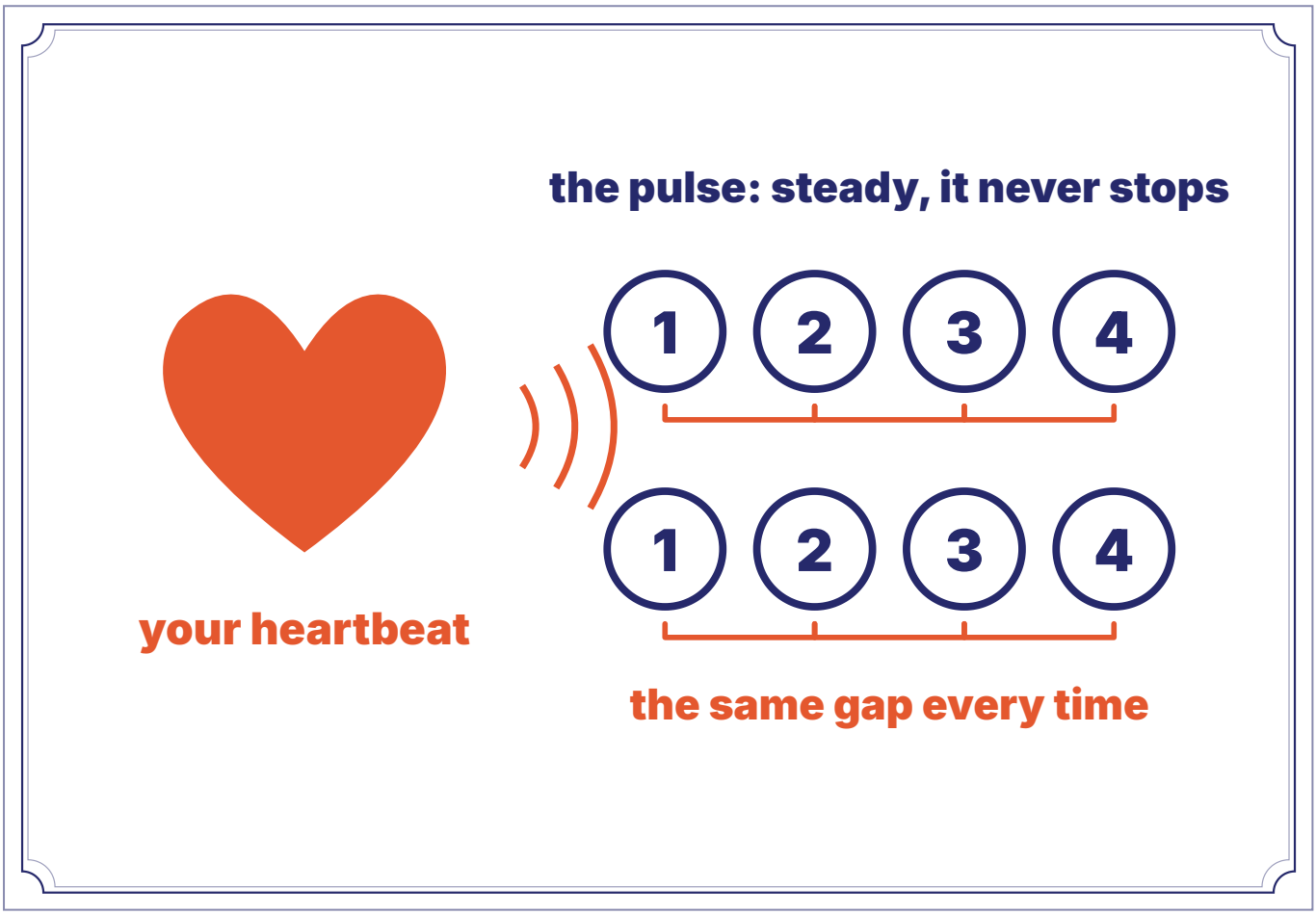
CHAPTER 3

Pulse & Counting

Music has a heartbeat: the **pulse**. It keeps going, steady, with **the same gap every time**, even when the notes stop. In this chapter you feel it, count it out loud, and keep it going at the piano.



In this chapter

- ☐ A steady beat 2
- ☐ Count out loud 3
- ☐ When the notes stop 4
- ☐ Beat or rhythm? 5
- ☐ The beat in your fingers 6
- ☐ My five checks 7

By the end, you can

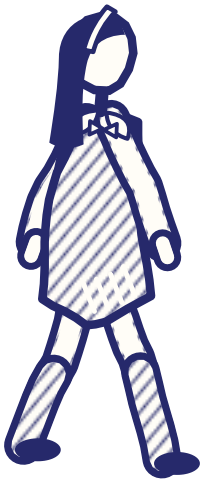
- ☐ pat a steady beat, the same gap every time
- ☐ count out loud, 1 2 3 4, while you pat
- ☐ keep counting through silent beats
- ☐ tell the beat from the rhythm
- ☐ play a new finger on each beat and count out loud

online

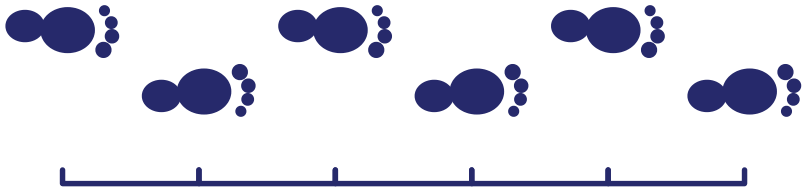
STEP 1

A steady beat

A **steady beat** has **the same gap every time**, like your heartbeat, a ticking clock, or your feet when you walk. Not steady means the gaps change: shorter, longer, a stop, then go again. The beat of music is steady.



✔ steady



the same gap every time

× not steady



At the piano

1. Pat your knees with both hands, 8 times, steady: the same gap every time, like a clock. ☐
2. Walk 8 steps across the room: one step on each beat, the same gap every time. ☐

REMEMBER **A steady beat: the same gap every time.**

LESSON STEP 1

online

TRY IT Steady or not?

Look at the gaps between the footprints. Tick a trail with the same gap every time; cross a trail whose gaps change.

EXAMPLE



2



3



4



YOUR TURN Steady or not, on your own

Tick or cross. Look carefully: one gap that changes makes a trail not steady.

5



6



7



8



★ PLAY Keep the trail going

Draw the next two footprints on each trail, the same gap every time. Then walk it across the room: one step on each beat, counting 1 2 3 4.

9



10



11



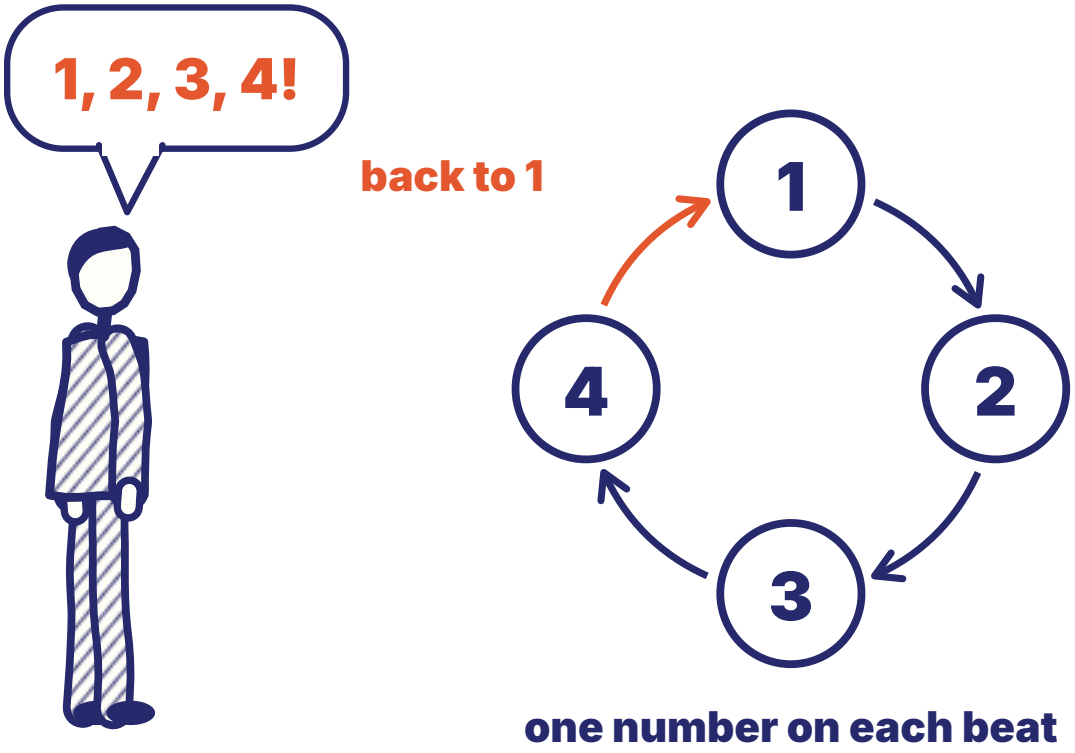
How did it feel? Circle one.

CHECKED ☐

STEP 2

Count out loud

Give every beat a number: **1 2 3 4**, then start again at 1. Say it out loud, one number on each beat, the same gap every time. Counting out loud keeps the beat steady, and later it tells you where every note goes.



At the piano

1. Pat your knees and count out loud: 1 2 3 4, four times round, without stopping. ☐
2. Right hand: finger 3 on the right black key of the 4th small house. Play it on every beat and count: 1 2 3 4, four times round. ☐

REMEMBER **Count out loud: 1 2 3 4, then 1 again.**

LESSON STEP 2

online

TRY IT Number the beats

Write the count in every empty circle: 1 2 3 4, then start again at 1.

EXAMPLE

1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

2

1 ○ ○ ○ 1 ○ ○ ○

3

1 ○ ○ 4 ○ ○ 3 ○

4

○ 2 ○ ○ ○ 2 ○ ○

YOUR TURN What comes next?

The count goes round: after 4 comes 1. Write the next four numbers.

5

3 4 ○ ○ ○ ○

6

2 3 ○ ○ ○ ○

7

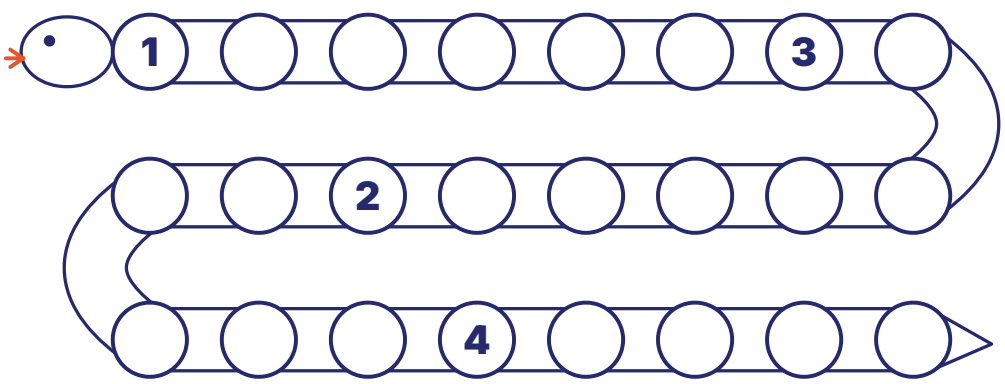
4 1 ○ ○ ○ ○

8

1 2 ○ ○ ○ ○

★ PLAY The counting snake

Fill in the whole snake, from its head to its tail. Then pat your knees and count it out loud, one number on each pat.



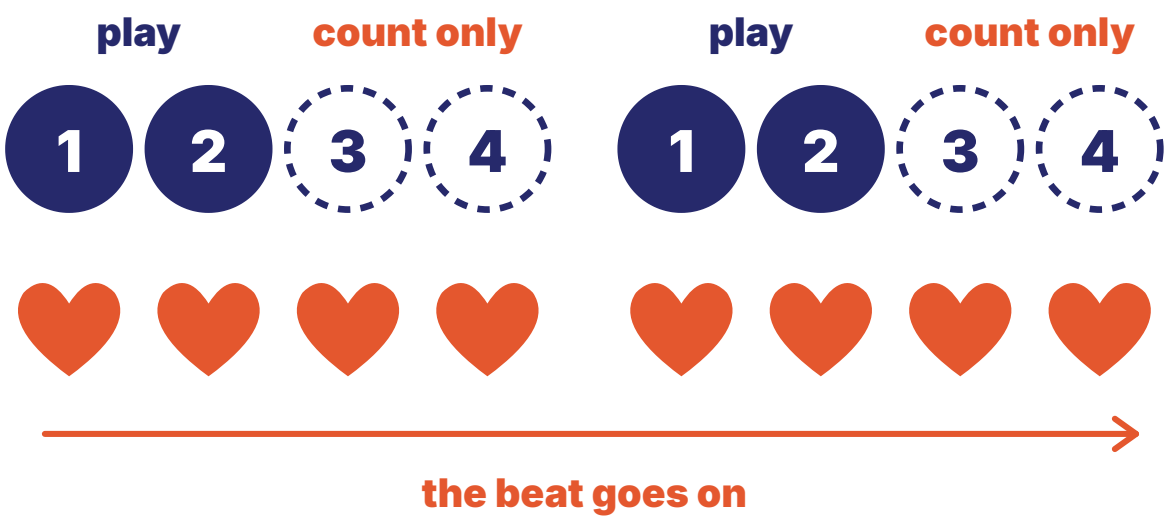
How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹

CHECKED ☐

STEP 3

When the notes stop

The beat does not stop when you stop playing. Play on 1 and 2, lift your hand on 3 and 4, and keep counting: **the silent beats still count**. Then you come back in at the right time.



At the piano

1. Right hand, finger 3 on the right black key of the 4th small house: play on 1 and 2, lift on 3 and 4, and keep counting out loud. Four times round. ☐
2. Now play only on 1, and count 2 3 4 with your hand just above the key. Four times round. ☐

REMEMBER **Silent beats still count.**

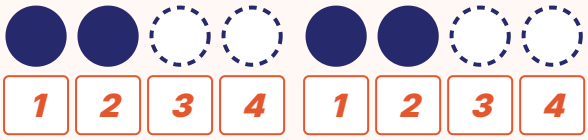
LESSON STEP 3

online

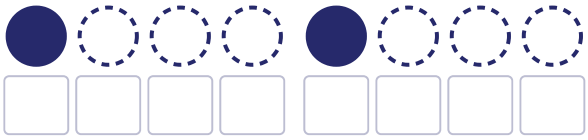
TRY IT Count every beat

Write the count under every circle: the navy ones you play and the dashed silent ones too.

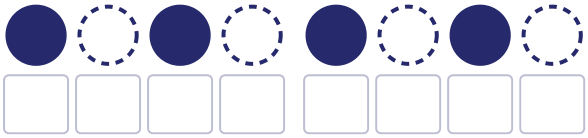
EXAMPLE



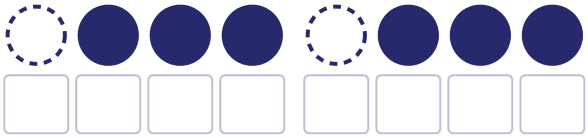
2



3



4



YOUR TURN Colour the beats you play

Colour the circles you play. Leave the silent beats white and dashed.

EXAMPLE

Play on 1 and 3



6

Play only on 4



7

Play on 1, 2 and 4



8

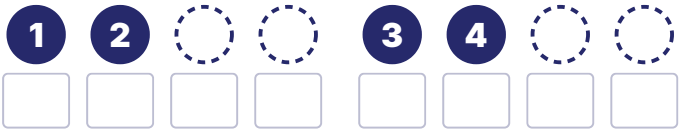
Play on 2 and 3



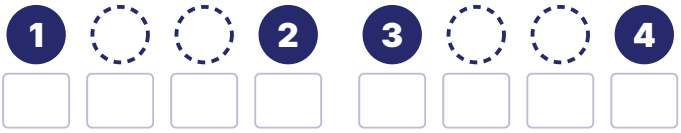
★ PLAY Fix the count

Only the played notes got a number here. Write the right count under every circle, then play each row: right hand, finger 3, the 4th small house.

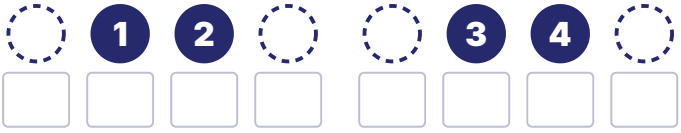
9



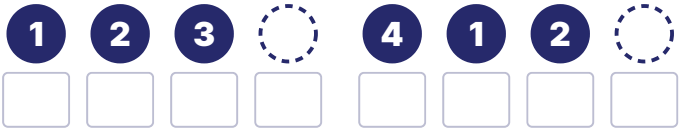
10



11



12

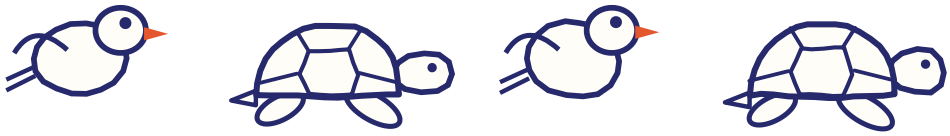


How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹ CHECKED ☐

STEP 4

Beat or rhythm?

The **beat** is the steady heartbeat underneath. The **rhythm** is the pattern of sounds on top, long and short, like the sounds of words. Say **bird** on one beat: one sound. Say **tur-tle** on one beat: two sounds. The beat stays the same; the rhythm changes.



	bird	tur-tle	bird	tur-tle
rhythm the sounds	●	● ●	●	● ●
beat steady	♥	♥	♥	♥

At the piano

1. Tap the beat with your foot and say: bird, tur-tle, bird, tur-tle, one word on each beat. Then clap the words while your foot keeps the beat. ☐
2. Now: tur-tle, tur-tle, bird, bird. And: light-house, bird, light-house, bird. ☐

REMEMBER **The beat stays steady; the rhythm is the sounds on top.**

LESSON STEP 4

online

TRY IT One dot for each sound

Say each row, one word on each heart. Draw one dot over a word for each sound.

EXAMPLE

tur-tle	bird	bird	tur-tle
♥	♥	♥	♥

2

bird	light-house	bird	bird
♥	♥	♥	♥

3

tur-tle	tur-tle	light-house	bird
♥	♥	♥	♥

4

light-house	tur-tle	bird	tur-tle
♥	♥	♥	♥

YOUR TURN Beats and sounds

How many beats? How many sounds? Draw the dots, then write both numbers.

5

bird	bird	bird	tur-tle
♥	♥	♥	♥

beats ☐ sounds ☐

6

tur-tle	tur-tle	tur-tle	tur-tle
♥	♥	♥	♥

beats ☐ sounds ☐

7

light-house	bird	tur-tle	bird
♥	♥	♥	♥

beats ☐ sounds ☐

8

bird	bird	bird	bird
♥	♥	♥	♥

beats ☐ sounds ☐

★ PLAY Words from dots

One dot: write bird. Two dots: write tur-tle. Then say each row, tapping the beat with your foot.

9	●	● ●	● ●	●
	♥	♥	♥	♥
10	● ●	●	● ●	● ●
	♥	♥	♥	♥
11	●	●	●	● ●
	♥	♥	♥	♥

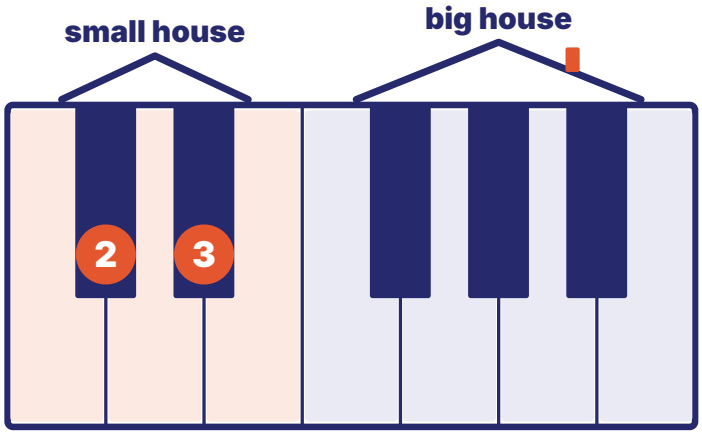
How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹

CHECKED ☐

STEP 5

The beat in your fingers

Now your fingers take turns: a new finger on each beat. Play each row twice and count out loud: 1 2 3 4. The numbers in the coral circles are finger numbers.



fingers

2 3 2 3

1 2 3 4

say: 1 2 3 4

Small-house beat

right hand, fingers 2 and 3 on the 4th small house

2 3 2 3 2 3 2 3

Big-house beat

right hand, fingers 2 3 4 on the big house next to it

2 3 4 3 2 3 4 3

Left-hand beat

left hand, fingers 3 and 2 on the 3rd small house

3 2 3 2 3 2 3 2

REMEMBER **A new finger on each beat; keep counting.**

LESSON STEP 5

online

TRY IT Which finger on the beat?

Which finger plays on the beat asked for? Write its number in the box.

EXAMPLE

2 3 2 3
1 2 3 4

on 3: 2

2

2 3 4 3
1 2 3 4

on 2: ☐

3

3 2 3 2
1 2 3 4

on 4: ☐

4

2 3 4 3
1 2 3 4

on 3: ☐

YOUR TURN Keep the pattern going

Write the finger numbers for the next four beats: the same pattern again. Then play each row, counting out loud.

5

2 3 2 3 ○ ○ ○ ○
1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

6

2 3 4 3 ○ ○ ○ ○
1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

7

3 2 3 2 ○ ○ ○ ○
1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

8

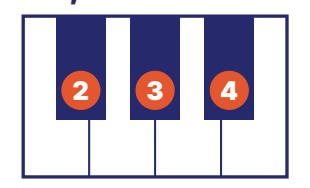
4 3 2 3 ○ ○ ○ ○
1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4

★ PLAY Read the keys

Over each key: the beats it plays on. Write the finger for each beat, then play it: right hand, the big house next to the 4th small house.

9

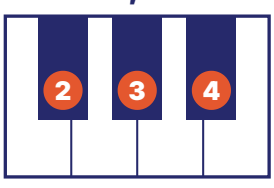
1, 3 2 4



○ ○ ○ ○
1 2 3 4

10

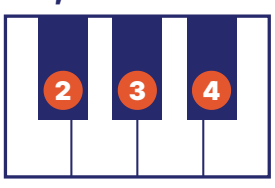
1 2, 4 3



○ ○ ○ ○
1 2 3 4

11

2, 4 3 1



○ ○ ○ ○
1 2 3 4

How did it feel? Circle one. ☺ 😐 ☹

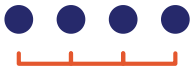
CHECKED ☐

CHECK-UP

My five checks

Show each one at the piano, then colour a circle for how it is going: not yet, nearly, or got it! The check-up on paper is in the Workbook.

At the piano

	NOT YET	NEARLY	GOT IT!
 **I can pat a steady beat: the same gap every time**	○	◑	☆
 **I can count out loud, 1 2 3 4, while I pat**	○	◑	☆
 **I can keep counting through silent beats**	○	◑	☆
 **I can tell the beat from the rhythm: my foot keeps the beat, my hands clap the words**	○	◑	☆
 **I can play a new finger on each beat and count out loud**	○	◑	☆

Colour a circle each time it gets better: not yet, then nearly, then got it!

On paper

Name _____ Date _____ · no help, no piano · about 10 minutes

A Steady or not? Tick a steady trail; cross a trail whose gaps change.

1



✓ ✗

2



✓ ✗

3



✓ ✗

4



✓ ✗

B Write the count in every empty circle: 1 2 3 4, then 1 again.

5

1 ○ ○ ○ ○ 2 ○ ○

6

○ ○ 3 ○ 1 ○ ○ ○

7

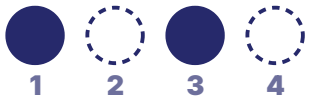
○ 2 ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ 4

8

○ ○ ○ 4 ○ ○ 3 ○

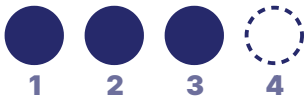
C Which beats do you play? Write their numbers.

9



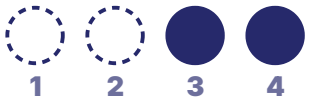
_____

10



_____

11



_____

12



_____

D Four beats: how many sounds? Write the number.

13

tur-tle bird bird bird

_____

14

light-house bird bird tur-tle

_____

15

bird tur-tle bird bird

_____

16

tur-tle bird tur-tle tur-tle

_____

E Which finger plays on the beat asked for?

17



on 3: _____

18



on 2: _____

19



on 4: _____

20



on 1: _____

Teacher copy · Pulse & Counting

Each workbook page faces its Lesson Book page. The book uses **pulse** in the title and the opener and **beat** everywhere else (Korean: 박). It counts **1 2 3 4** only. Later: strong and weak beats (chapter 8, Time signatures); note values, rest names and + for "and" (chapter 5: 1 + 2 + 3 + 4 +, then 1 e + a 2 e + a); speed (chapter 13, Tempo). A silent beat is a dashed circle with no rest name yet. AMEB: practical, the groundwork for 2/4 and 3/4 at Preliminary.

Lesson time: walk, then run. Walk round the room to a steady beat: one step on each beat. Later, running (two quick steps on each beat) becomes two quavers, counted 1 + 2 + in chapter 5. In this chapter, keep to walking.

p. 2 A steady beat

TRY IT 1. **steady ✓** 2. **not steady ×** 3. **not steady ×** 4. **steady ✓**

YOUR TURN 5. **not steady ×** 6. **steady ✓** 7. **steady ✓** 8. **not steady ×**

PLAY **9 to 11: two more footprints on each trail, the same gap as the first three**

Watch for

Judging a trail by its length instead of its gaps. Missing a single gap that changes (3 and 8). When the student pats or walks: speeding up as the beat goes on, slowing down, or stopping to think: the count must stay steady.

If stuck, try saying

"Look between the feet: is every gap the same?"

p. 3 Count out loud

TRY IT **1 to 4: 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 in every row**

YOUR TURN 5. **3 4 1 2 3 4** 6. **2 3 4 1 2 3** 7. **4 1 2 3 4 1** 8. **1 2 3 4 1 2**

PLAY 9. **1 2 3 4 six times round, from the head to the tail**

Watch for

Counting on past 4 ("5, 6"). Playing or patting the first beat and only then starting the count, so the count lands late and every number is behind its beat: the number and the beat start together. Letting the count speed up or slow down: it should be as steady as the beat.

If stuck, try saying

"Say 1 at the same moment as you pat: number and pat together."

p. 4 When the notes stop

TRY IT **1 to 4: 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 under every row, the silent circles too**

YOUR TURN 5. **1 3** 6. **only 4** 7. **1 2 4** 8. **2 3**

PLAY **9 to 12: 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 under every row (the numbers in the circles counted only the notes)**

Watch for

Writing numbers only under the played circles. At the piano: stopping the count when the hand lifts, or rushing through the silent beats to the next note, so the next 1 comes early. Numbers 4 and 11 begin with a silent beat: the count still starts on 1.

If stuck, try saying

"Your hand stops; your count doesn't."

p. 5 Beat or rhythm?

TRY IT 1. **2 1 1 2 dots** 2. **1 2 1 1 dots** 3. **2 2 2 1 dots** 4. **2 2 1 2 dots**

YOUR TURN 5. **4 beats, 5 sounds** 6. **4 beats, 8 sounds** 7. **4 beats, 6 sounds** 8. **4 beats, 4 sounds**

PLAY 9. **bird tur-tle tur-tle bird** 10. **tur-tle bird tur-tle tur-tle** 11. **bird bird bird tur-tle**

Watch for
Tapping the foot on every sound of the words instead of the beat (the commonest mix-up). Giving a two-sound word two beats. Number 8: bird bird bird bird has 4 beats and 4 sounds: here the rhythm and the beat are the same.

If stuck, try saying
"The foot is the heartbeat: it never changes. The hands say the words."

p. 6 The beat in your fingers

TRY IT 1. **on 3: finger 2** 2. **on 2: finger 3** 3. **on 4: finger 2** 4. **on 3: finger 4**

YOUR TURN 5. **2 3 2 3 2 3 2 3** 6. **2 3 4 3 2 3 4 3** 7. **3 2 3 2 3 2 3 2** 8. **4 3 2 3 4 3 2 3**

PLAY 9. **2 3 2 4** 10. **2 3 4 3** 11. **4 2 3 2**

Watch for
Reading the finger numbers as the count, or the count as finger numbers: the coral circles are fingers, the numbers under them are the count. Pausing to find the next finger, so the beat stops: put every finger on its key before the count starts. Playing the first note and then starting the count late.

If stuck, try saying
"Coral is the finger, the number under it is the count. Keep the count going even while you look."

p. 7 The check-up on paper (the Workbook's last page)

A 1. **not steady ×** 2. **steady ✓** 3. **not steady ×** 4. **not steady ×**

B **5 to 8: 1 2 3 4 1 2 3 4 in every row**

C 9. **1 3** 10. **1 2 3** 11. **3 4** 12. **1 4**

D 13. **5** 14. **6** 15. **5** 16. **7**

E 17. **finger 4** 18. **finger 2** 19. **finger 3** 20. **finger 4**

Four marks for each section. The paper shows the idea; the beat itself is heard: also listen to the student pat and count (My five checks, Lesson Book page 7).

If a concept is not passed, go back to: **A** Lesson step 1, workbook page 2 · **B** Lesson step 2, workbook page 3 · **C** Lesson step 3, workbook page 4 · **D** Lesson step 4, workbook page 5 · **E** Lesson step 5, workbook page 6